

concept of an anchor in this high-tempo format.

Skipper Suryakumar Yadav has been short of runs over the last seven months, averaging 18.46. At the World Cup, the team will need him to convert flashes of brilliance into sustained impact. The only concern is Tilak Varma’s fitness following a minor groin procedure. The Hyderabad batter provides a solid left-handed option through the middle and has delivered on big occasions, as exhibited in the Asia Cup final. With Shivam Dube bowling regularly, the side has also been able to slot in Rinku Singh to add late-innings power alongside Hardik.

Across the border, Pakistan has had 44 matches to plan its World Cup strategy after a dismal outing last time, when it lost to the USA and failed to progress beyond the preliminary stage. After moving past Babar Azam and Mohammad Rizwan midway through last year, Pakistan has decided to recall Babar for this World Cup. Slotting him in might push Fakhar Zaman out of the playing eleven.

The Salman Ali Agha-led side’s primary weakness is its middle order. Pakistan batters in positions four to eight have averaged just 17.61 since the previous edition, the fourth-worst among all participating teams. Their strike rates also lag behind other top contenders. Spinner Abrar Ahmed’s form will play a major role in how the team’s bowling fares, with the pace attack remaining



expensive despite its wicket-taking ability. Fast bowlers Haris Rauf and Mohammad Wasim Jnr have been left out.

The Netherlands has opted for a host of changes to the team that took the field in its last T20I series away in Bangladesh. The side, led by Scott Edwards, has recalled experienced players, with Colin Ackermann, Roelof van der Merwe (pic, left) and Timm van der Gugten all returning after a period out. The Dutch have shown in past World Cups that they are capable of upsetting higher-ranked teams, but qualification to the next stage appears unlikely.

Namibia qualified for the tournament after finishing runner-up in the Africa qualifier and has opted for continuity, with 10 players from the 2024 squad retaining their spots. However, the experience of David Wiese, who retired after the last World Cup, will be a major miss. The United States booked its place in the tournament after an underdog performance at home in 2024, managing to sneak into the final-eight stage.

The side is the lowest-ranked in Group A and will have its task cut out. A 3-0 T20I series win over Oman in early 2025 would have given it a sense of the conditions in this part of the world.

(Stats as of January 22)

Group A – T20 World Cup record

Team	Matches Played	Won	Lost	Tie	No Result	Titles won
India	52	35	15	1	1	2 (2007, 2024)
Pakistan	51	30	19	2	–	1 (2009)
Netherlands	27	10	16	–	1	–
Namibia	15	4	10	1	–	–
USA	6	1	4	1	–	–